Singapore Travel Guide

A garden city-state of food, culture and futuristic design - Singapore

Singapore: Overview and History

Singapore is an island city-state at the southern tip of the Malay Peninsula in South-East Asia. In 1819 Sir Stamford Raffles of the British East India Company established a trading post here, and Singapore grew into a busy port of the British Empire, ruled from London.

Singapore became independent in 1965 after separating from Malaysia. Under its first Prime Minister, Lee Kuan Yew, the small nation quickly developed into one of the richest and most modern countries in the world.

Singapore has four official languages: English, Malay, Mandarin and Tamil, reflecting its Chinese, Malay and Indian communities. It is known as a garden city because of its many parks and green buildings.

The city is famous for being very clean and safe. Strict rules include fines for littering, and the sale of chewing gum is banned.

Singapore: Top Attractions

Gardens by the Bay is a futuristic park next to Marina Bay. Its giant tree-like structures, the Supertrees, light up during the free Garden Rhapsody show every evening. The Cloud Forest and Flower Dome are huge cooled glass conservatories filled with plants from around the world.

Marina Bay Sands is a hotel with three towers joined at the top by the SkyPark, which has an observation deck and a famous infinity pool for hotel guests. Across the bay, the Merlion statue, half lion and half fish, is the symbol of Singapore.

The Singapore Botanic Gardens are a UNESCO World Heritage Site and include the National Orchid Garden. The Singapore Zoo and the Night Safari are among the best wildlife parks in the world. Sentosa Island has beaches, Universal Studios Singapore and other attractions.

Jewel Changi Airport features the Rain Vortex, the world's tallest indoor waterfall at about 40 metres. The historic Raffles Hotel, named after the city's founder, is where the Singapore Sling cocktail was invented.

Singapore: Neighborhoods and Food

Chinatown has temples, shophouses and street markets, including the Buddha Tooth Relic Temple. Little India is full of colour, spice shops and the Sri Veeramakaliamman Temple. Kampong Glam, the Malay and Arab quarter, is home to the golden-domed Sultan Mosque and the trendy Haji Lane.

Tiong Bahru is an older residential area with art deco flats and cafes, and Clarke Quay is a riverside nightlife area.

Food is a national passion. Hawker centres are open-air food courts with dozens of stalls selling cheap and delicious meals, and Singapore's hawker culture was added to the UNESCO list of Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2020. Popular hawker centres include Maxwell Food Centre and Lau Pa Sat, famous for its evening satay street.

Must-try dishes include Hainanese chicken rice, laksa (spicy coconut noodle soup), chilli crab, char kway teow (fried noodles) and kaya toast with soft-boiled eggs for breakfast.

Singapore: Getting Around and Practical Tips

Singapore's MRT metro system is clean, fast and easy to use. You can tap in with a contactless bank card or an EZ-Link card. Buses cover the whole island, and taxis and Grab ride-hailing cars are affordable.

Changi Airport is regularly voted the best airport in the world. To get from Changi Airport to the city, take the MRT East West Line, changing at Tanah Merah; the journey to the centre takes about 30 to 40 minutes. Taxis take about 20 minutes.

Changi is the hub of Singapore Airlines, which flies to Tokyo, Sydney, London and New York. Its non-stop flight from Singapore to New York is one of the longest flights in the world, at around 18 hours. The currency is the Singapore dollar (SGD).

Singapore is hot and humid all year, with temperatures around 30 degrees Celsius. February to April is usually the driest and sunniest period, while the north-east monsoon brings heavy rain from November to January. Carry an umbrella and expect strong air conditioning indoors.

Singapore: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Explore Marina Bay, see the Merlion, go up to the Marina Bay Sands SkyPark and watch the Garden Rhapsody light show at Gardens by the Bay. Day 2: Walk through Chinatown, have lunch at Maxwell Food Centre, then explore Little India and Kampong Glam.

Day 3: Visit the Singapore Botanic Gardens in the morning, spend the afternoon on Sentosa Island, and end with the Night Safari.

Pulau Ubin is a rustic island reached by bumboat, where visitors cycle past old villages and mangroves. Ferries go to the Indonesian island of Bintan for beach resorts, and Johor Bahru in Malaysia is just across the causeway.

Singapore is a popular stopover between Europe and Australia, linking London with Sydney, and a short flight from Tokyo and other Asian cities.